MERCHANT SERVICES · PRODUCT

Product Team Operating Model

Work intake, lifecycle and cadence for Strategic Initiatives, Payment Brand Initiatives and Platform Enhancements across UPOP, Credential Vault, Authentication Optimization and Payment Instrument Intelligence.

PROCESS 01

Strategic Initiatives

New capabilities that move platform strategy

PROCESS 02

Payment Brand Initiatives

Network mandates and their upstream product impact

PROCESS 03

Platform Enhancements

Run the product: Day-2, carryover, client asks

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One engine, three entry doors

All product work runs as three streams, **Strategic Initiatives (SI)**, **Payment Brand Initiatives (PBI)** and **Platform Enhancements (PE)**, through one intake, one lifecycle and one ranked backlog. Each month the Product Backlog Refinement (PBR) gets work ready. Each quarter the Product Increment (PI) commits it.

The streams differ in who sets priority and what triggers them. They do not differ in how work gets designed. That is the core design choice here.

Stream	What it covers	Who sets priority and timing	Product team's job
SI **Strategic**	New capabilities that move the platform strategy	Product leadership, against the roadmap	Own the solution end to end
PBI **Payment Brand**	Network mandates that reach front-end products, not the payment rails	PBI team, bound by the mandate's effective date	Find the upstream impact and deliver the solution on time
PE **Platform Enh.**	Run the product: Day-2 fallout, partial PBI carryover, client asks, non-mandated network items	Product leadership, inside a protected capacity floor	Keep the products current and competitive

Products in scope

Product	Scope for this model
Payment processing front end (UPOP)	Merchant-facing orchestration, APIs and processing logic, not the payment rails
Credential Vault	Card and token storage, network token lifecycle
Authentication Optimization	3DS/SCA flows, exemptions, authentication decisioning
Payment Instrument Intelligence	BIN and instrument attributes used by routing and other products

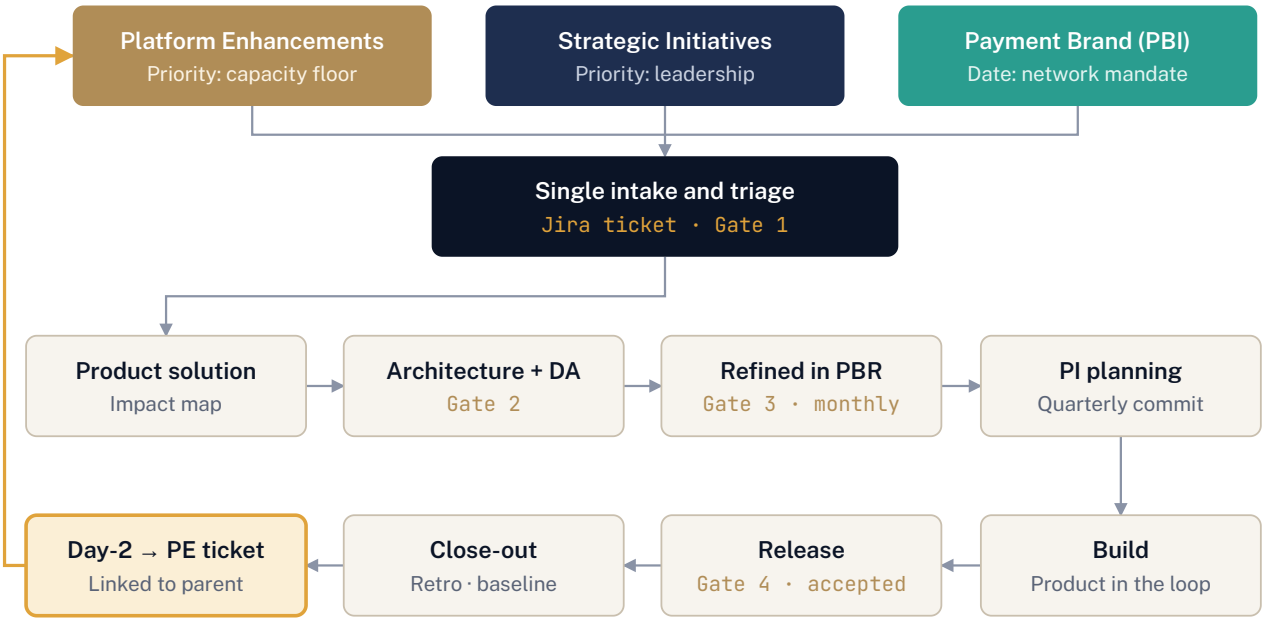
Constraints this model is built around

- The same Solution Architects, Design Authority and tech leads serve all three streams. Every stream competes for the same scarce design time.
- The networks fix PBI deadlines. PBI takes first claim on capacity, whether or not the plan has room.
- PE has no natural sponsor. Without a protected allocation, it loses to SI and PBI every PI.
- Cross-product impact is the hardest call and the one most often missed. A change in one product often lands in another.

One front door, nine stages, four gates

Every item in every stream moves through the same nine stages and four gates. Rules specific to a stream sit on top of this spine and never replace it.

Three streams share one lifecycle; Day-2 work loops back as PE



Every deferred item becomes a linked PE ticket, so run-the-product work is never lost.

One front door

All work enters Jira as an intake item tagged SI, PBI or PE. No ticket means no work. That includes client escalations that arrive through sales or go straight to a tech lead.

Minimum intake fields (triage sends back anything incomplete):

- The problem or mandate in one paragraph, and the outcome wanted
- Source: sponsor, network bulletin, client or parent initiative
- Products believed to be affected (any of the four)
- Hard dates, and why they are hard
- Client asks: the client, commercial value or revenue at risk, and whether the ask is custom or platform

Lifecycle and gates

1. Intake: item logged with minimum fields
2. Triage: accept, decline, merge or re-route; lead PM named `GATE 1`
3. Product solution: solution brief and cross-product impact map
4. Architecture and DA: Sol Arch design; DA decision recorded `GATE 2`
5. Refinement (PBR): epics and features meet Definition of Ready `GATE 3`
6. PI planning: committed within the stream's capacity
7. Build: product stays involved through weekly design forums
8. Release: product accepts against the acceptance criteria `GATE 4`
9. Close-out: every gap or Day-2 item becomes a linked PE ticket

Roles

Activity	Product (you, PMs)	POs	Sol Arch	Design Authority	Tech leads	PMO	PBI team	Leadership
Intake and triage	**A**	C	I	—	I	I	C (PBI)	I
Product solution	**A**	R	C	—	C	—	C (PBI)	—
Architecture design	C	C	R	**A**	C	—	—	—
Refinement (PBR)	**A**	R	C	—	R	—	—	—
Delivery tracking	C	C	—	—	R	**A**	C (PBI)	I
Day-2 and gap decisions	**A**	R	C	C	C	I	C (PBI)	I
Priority across streams	R	—	—	—	C	—	Sets PBI dates	**A**

R = Responsible · A = Accountable · C = Consulted · I = Informed

Definition of Ready GATE 3

- Problem, outcome and acceptance criteria are written
- The cross-product impact map is complete, and every "no impact" call has a reason
- The DA decision is recorded, and every open design question has an owner and a date
- Non-functional needs are stated: latency, availability, PCI scope, network certification
- Day-1 scope and Day-2 candidates are explicitly separated
- The work is sized and its dependencies are named

Definition of Done GATE 4

- Product has confirmed and signed off the acceptance criteria
- Network certification or compliance evidence is stored, where required
- Client-facing documentation and release notes are updated
- Every descoped item exists as a linked PE ticket with a reason and an owner

Prioritization across streams

1. Mandated PBI work takes first claim on capacity, sized to meet the deadline.
2. Leadership splits the remaining capacity between SI and PE each PI. A starting point to calibrate against: roughly **60% SI / 40% PE**.
3. Within a stream, rank with a lightweight WSJF score: value, time criticality and risk reduction, divided by size.
4. An **expedite lane**, capped at a small share of capacity, covers production-affecting client escalations between PIs.

Strategic Initiatives

This stream is where product earns its seat. The team decides how a new capability fits across all four products before engineering designs it. The risks to manage are scope that grows during build and Day-2 items that never come back.

	Step	Owner	What happens	Exit criterion
01	**Intake**	Sponsor, via lead PM	Initiative logged with outcome, sponsor, target window and products believed to be affected	Minimum fields complete
02	**Triage**	Product leadership (weekly)	Accept, decline, merge with an existing initiative, or re-route to PE; size S/M/L; name a lead PM	Decision logged GATE 1
03	**Product solution**	Lead PM with POs	Solution brief covering how it fits the platform, what changes in each product, a cross-product impact map, Day-1 vs Day-2 candidates and open questions	Brief reviewed in the product design forum
04	**Architecture and DA**	Sol Arch; DA decides	Solution design against the brief; DA review; decisions recorded as ADRs	DA approval GATE 2
05	**Refinement**	POs and tech leads (monthly PBR)	Break into epics and features; acceptance criteria; sizing	Definition of Ready met GATE 3
06	**Plan and track**	PMO	Committed at PI planning; milestones, RAID log and cross-team dependencies worked in Scrum of Scrums	Committed in the PI plan
07	**Build**	Tech leads, product in the loop	The weekly design forum answers product questions; any scope change goes through the decision log	Features complete
08	**Gaps and Day-2**	Lead PM	Work discovered during build is triaged: absorb it, trade something out, or move it to Day-2 as a linked PE ticket	Every gap has a disposition
09	**Release and close**	Lead PM	Acceptance against criteria; success metric baselined; short retrospective	Accepted GATE 4

Rules specific to SI

- Any scope change after Gate 2 needs a logged trade-off: what moves out, or what date moves.
- Product answers questions raised during build within **two business days**. Otherwise the question goes to the next leadership forum.
- Close-out is not complete until every Day-2 item is a PE ticket with a parent link, a reason and an owner.

Payment Brand Initiatives

In PBI the date is not yours to set. The product team adds value through fast, accurate impact analysis. The PBI team owns the mandate and the rails. Product owns what that mandate does to the four front-end products upstream.

	Step	Owner	What happens	Exit criterion
01	**Mandate intake**	PBI team	Mandate logged with network, bulletin reference, effective date, compliance deadline and scope on the rail side	PBI intake ticket exists
02	**Impact screen**	Lead PM (fixed SLA from intake)	Run the product impact checklist below and produce an impact matrix per product: none, low or high	Impact matrix signed off
03	**Route**	Product leadership	No impact: close with a written reason. Rails only: the PBI team owns it and product is informed. Front-end impact: continue	Decision logged GATE 1
04	**Product solution**	Lead PM with POs	Split scope into the mandated minimum (must ship by the deadline) and value-add (moves to PE)	Brief reviewed
05	**Architecture and DA**	Sol Arch; DA decides	Design with interfaces to the rail teams confirmed; decisions recorded	DA approval GATE 2
06	**Refinement**	POs and tech leads	Make work ready, sized back from the compliance date, including network certification time	Ready GATE 3
07	**Coordinate**	PMO	Mandate calendar; deadline tracking; coordination across the PBI team, rail teams and product teams	Committed in the PI plan
08	**Build**	Tech leads, product in the loop	Weekly design forum; any threat to the deadline is escalated the same week	Features complete
09	**Certify and close**	Lead PM with PBI team	Network testing or certification; compliance evidence stored; carryover becomes linked PE tickets	Accepted GATE 4

Product impact checklist

The question for each product: *does this mandate change what we send, store, decide or expose?*

Product	Questions to answer
Payment processing front end (UPOP)	New or changed fields in merchant APIs? New data elements to carry into authorization? Changed response codes or retry rules? A merchant-facing change that needs client notice?
Credential Vault	Changes to token provisioning, lifecycle or cryptogram handling? Rules for card-on-file or stored-credential indicators? A change to data retention or PCI scope?
Authentication Optimization	3DS version or message changes? New exemption or indicator rules? Changed liability shift or challenge flows?
Payment Instrument Intelligence	New or changed BIN ranges, product IDs or attributes? Downstream consumers of those attributes affected?

Rules specific to PBI

- The impact screen starts when the mandate is announced, not when rail work starts. Ask the PBI team to send mandates at announcement.
- The deadline is fixed; scope and approach can flex. Anything beyond the mandated minimum goes to PE.
- Every "no impact" call is written down with its reason. It is the call most likely to be wrong and the hardest to trace later.

Platform Enhancements: run the product

PE is a continuous flow, not a project. Anyone can capture an item at any time. Items are submitted through **SIF**, made ready monthly, and pulled into each PI inside a protected capacity floor. PE keeps the four products current and makes sure Day-2 promises are kept.

Sources of PE work

Source	Arrives from	Required on the ticket
SI Day-2 and gaps	SI close-out or decisions made during build	Parent SI link, reason deferred, owner
PBI carryover	Partially implemented mandates; value-add beyond the minimum	Parent PBI link; whether any part is still mandated
Client asks	Clients, sales, relationship managers	Client, commercial value, custom or platform
Non-mandated network items	Optional network programs and recommendations	Network reference, benefit to merchants
Team-identified	POs, tech leads, incidents, competitive gaps	Evidence and the product affected

Flow

	Stage	Cadence	What happens
01	**Capture**	`Continuous`	Anyone on the team logs a PE item in Jira with the source fields above.
02	**Groom**	`Weekly`	A backlog review with Pratik, Vishal and the POs flags items that need clarity, definition or a product solution.
03	**Submit through SIF**	`Monthly`	Groomed PE items go through **SIF**, the PE intake process, so tech capacity is allocated before that month's PBR.
04	**Refine**	`Monthly PBR`	Each item is designed and solutioned to Definition of Ready, so it can be picked up in the next PI.
05	**Commit**	`Quarterly PI`	Ranked PE work is pulled into the PE capacity floor.
06	**Track**	`Monthly`	Progress is reviewed with tech leads. A slipping item goes back through ranking instead of silently rolling forward.

Rules specific to PE

- **Classes of service.** Expedite (production-affecting client escalation) · Fixed-date (a client or network date) · Standard · Hygiene (debt and upkeep). Each class has its own share of capacity.
- **Custom vs platform.** A client ask built for one client only needs leadership sign-off. By default, generalize it into a platform capability or decline it.
- **Aging.** Any item untouched for two PIs is reviewed and then re-ranked, merged or closed with a reason. The original sponsor hears about any Day-2 item that is closed.
- **Visibility.** The leadership forum sees the size of the Day-2 and PE backlog per product every month. Run-the-product debt becomes visible before it becomes a client problem.

Meeting cadence

The five forums in the original notes stay. They are ordered so that each one's output feeds the next. Two forums the processes need are added: monthly PBR and a PBI mandate review. Durations are proposals.

Weekly, in order from Monday to Friday

Day	Forum	Purpose	Attendees	Output
MON	**Product design and triage** 60 min	Triage new intake; review solution briefs and requirements	Product team	Gate 1 decisions; briefs ready for DA
TUE	**Design review** 60 min	Resolve open design questions across products	DA, tech leads, POs, product	Gate 2 decisions; ADRs logged
WED	**Backlog review** 45 min	Find items that need clarity or definition; prepare PBR candidates; improve the PBR process	Pratik, Vishal, POs, product	Groomed backlog; SIF submissions
THU	**Delivery review** 30 min	Exceptions only: items off track against the PI plan	Tech leads, PMO, product	Escalations and decisions for Friday
FRI	**Leadership update** 30 min	Achievements, then Now / Next / Later; decisions needed	Leadership, product	Priority calls; escalations resolved

Monthly and quarterly

Cadence	Forum	Purpose	Attendees	Output
MONTHLY	**Product Backlog Refinement**	Design and solution SI and PE items to Definition of Ready	POs, tech leads, Sol Arch, product	Ready items for the next PI
MONTHLY	**PBI mandate review**	Walk the mandate calendar; confirm impact screens and deadlines at risk	PBI team, product, PMO	Updated impact matrix and mandate calendar
MONTHLY	**Leadership scorecard** (replaces one Friday)	Flow metrics; Day-2 and PE backlog per product	Leadership, product	Capacity and priority adjustments
QUARTERLY	**PI planning and review**	Commit the next PI by stream allocation; review the last PI's outcomes	Leadership, product, tech leads, PMO, PBI team	Committed PI plan; allocation set

Forum principles. Attendees read status in a Jira dashboard before the meeting; nobody presents it in the meeting, which is for decisions. Each forum has a chair, a decision log and a written output. A forum that makes no decisions for three weeks is cancelled or merged. Tech leads attend at most two weekly forums, and Thursday is exception-only to protect their time.

07 · MEASURES AND IMPROVEMENTS

How we will know it is working

A monthly scorecard gives leadership a view of flow and outcomes, not just activity.

Leadership scorecard

Targets set after two PIs of baseline

- Intake to Gate 1, and Gate 1 to Ready, in days, by stream
- Share of committed PI items that met Definition of Ready at planning
- PBI mandates at risk against their compliance date
- Day-2 and PE backlog size and age, by product
- Committed vs delivered per PI, by stream
- One outcome measure per product (e.g. authorization rate, token coverage, frictionless authentication rate)

Further improvements to consider

- **Platform product lead.** Rotate one PM each PI as owner of the cross-product view, so impact analysis does not rest on you alone.
- **Jira as the system of record.** One project with an issue type or label per stream, and dashboards that replace status slides.
- **Mandate calendar as a shared asset.** A rolling 12-month view of network dates, owned jointly with the PBI team.
- **Quarterly retrospective on the process itself.** Cut any step or forum that is not producing decisions.

08 · DECISIONS AND ROLLOUT

Open decisions and 30/60/90 rollout

Seven decisions need your call before rollout. Everything else can start this week.

Open decisions

- [ ] The monthly SIF cut-off date, so tech capacity is allocated before each PBR
- [ ] What the quarterly meeting is (assumed here to be PI planning and review)
- [ ] The starting SI / PE capacity split and the expedite cap
- [ ] The impact-screen SLA for PBI mandates, agreed with the PBI team
- [ ] Who chairs weekly triage, and whether a platform product lead rotates
- [ ] Jira structure: one project with stream tags, or separate projects
- [ ] Whether PBI covers all networks or only the card brands currently in scope

Rollout

Window	Focus	Done when
DAYS 1–30	Settle naming and open decisions; intake form and Jira fields; SIF cut-off; Definitions of Ready and Done; the new meeting calendar	The first triage and design review run in the new format
DAYS 31–60	A product impact checklist for each product; the Day-2-to-PE ticket rule; dashboards replace status slides; the first PBR and PBI mandate review under this model	Every open Day-2 item exists as a linked PE ticket
DAYS 61–90	First PI planning with stream allocation; first leadership scorecard; retrospective on the process	The next PI is committed by stream and baseline metrics are captured